

The Yoga Philosophy *Reading List*



Yoga Philosophy Certificate Program

ABOUT THE CERTIFICATE

This program provides a comprehensive overview of the seminal texts, traditions, and contemporary concerns that inform modern yoga practice. Modern yoga may have different goals and concerns than some of the early yoga traditions and yet, the historical texts and ancient living traditions still have much to offer. Modern practitioners of Yoga are forging a path that unites body with mind, history with the present moment, and personal practice with social responsibility. This 34 hour program aims to support this integration by providing the philosophical and practical foundation for a mature embodiment of all that Yoga has to offer.

Our “Yoga Philosophy: Texts, Traditions & Practices” Online Training Program is an innovative program that is the first of its kind. True to Embodied Philosophy’s commitment to the synergy of knowledge and experience, we have curated a program that brings together a faculty of scholar-practitioners from both devotional and academic contexts.

REGISTERING CREDIT HOURS

All Embodied Philosophy courses are eligible for non-contact continuing education training hours with Yoga Alliance. If you want more information, please contact Yoga Alliance by phone at 1-888-921-9642 or email info@yogaalliance.org. If you have questions about the course itself or the hours associated with it, contact us at hello@embodiedphilosophy.com.

[Join over 250 students who have taken and trust the Yoga Philosophy Certificate Program.](#)

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INTRO

The Yoga Philosophy Reading List is an educational resource from Embodied Philosophy. The reading list reflects the topics and foci that we explore in the Yoga Philosophy Online Training and Certificate Programs.

We have broken down the recommended books into categories that reflect the various aspects of our program and thus give what we believe to be a comprehensive overview and survey of yoga philosophy and the Indian traditions that make up its background, history and cultural context.

Note: this reading list should not be seen as “all there is to say on the subject”. Our aim was to, based on our knowledge and study, provide enough books to get you grounded without overwhelming you. We hope we’ve accomplished this at the very least, but we plan to keep making edits to this document over time. For further study, consider enrolling in our On-Demand 30 Hour [Yoga Philosophy Online Training Program](#).

History of Yoga

1. [Yoga, Karma, and Rebirth: A Brief History and Philosophy \(2009\) by Stephen Phillips](#)

“For serious yoga practitioners curious to know the ancient origins of the art, Stephen Phillips, a professional philosopher and sanskritist with a long-standing personal practice, lays out the philosophies of action, knowledge, and devotion as well as the process of meditation, reasoning, and self-analysis that formed the basis of yoga in ancient and classical India and continue to shape it today” (from the back cover). This is an excellent introduction to both some of the history and philosophy of yoga, with a strong emphasis on its relationship to modern postural considerations. This is a fantastic resource for any yoga philosophy student’s reading list, and should be on the list of required readings of any yoga teacher training.

2. [A Brief History of Yoga: From Its Tantric Roots to the Modern Yoga Studio \(2018\) by Ramesh Bjonnes](#)

Authored by faculty member Ramesh Bjonnes, this text uncovers the pervasive influence of the Tantric traditions upon the development of contemporary Yoga. This is a short, accessible book that offers an important discussion of an often overlooked element of Yoga history.

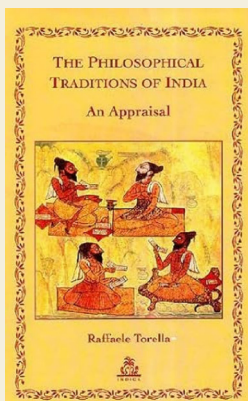
3. [Tracing the Path of Yoga: The History and Philosophy of Indian Mind-Body Discipline \(2021\) by Stuart Ray Sarbacker](#)

This new publication is a systematic, academic treatment of the history of Yoga from the Indus Civilization and Vedic traditions to the modern era. It includes chapters on early asceticism, Hindu epics, and the Medieval period of Bhakti, Haṭha, and Tantra. One of the great strengths of this volume is the footnotes and bibliographical references, which point towards an expansive list of resources for further study on a wide variety of specialized topics.

4. [The Truth of Yoga: A Comprehensive Guide to Yoga’s History, Texts, Philosophy, and Practices \(2021\) by Daniel Simpson](#)

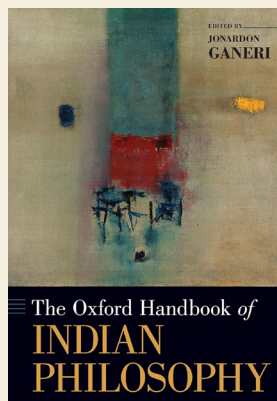
As faculty member Daniel Simpson’s first monograph, this comprehensive volume traces a myriad of traditions, philosophies, texts, practices, and key vocabulary words from the history of Yoga. It is written for a motivated and intelligent, yet not necessarily academic, audience. As such, it is highly accessible, providing nuance and depth without presuming any prior knowledge or study.

Indian Philosophy



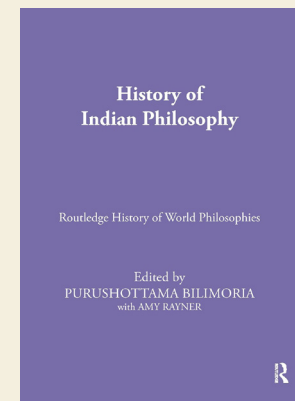
1. The Philosophical Traditions of India: An Appraisal (2011) by Raffaele Torella

Written by an excellent Italian scholar famous for his work on the pratjabhijñā philosopher Utpaladeva, Torella does an excellent job contextualizing the various streams and traditions of Indian philosophy, both those that are grouped under the banner of the Brahmanical/Vedic/Hindu tradition, and those that are not (such as Buddhism and Jainism). In this relatively short read, he offers a comprehensive understanding of what the various traditions have in common, and where they differ. While challenging for those who are new to yoga philosophy, this is a must-read.



2. The Oxford Handbook of Indian Philosophy (2017) by Jonardon Ganeri (Ed.)

This is a book of nearly 40 chapters with just as many scholars, giving you a taste not only of the vast landscape of Indian Philosophy, but also a glimpse into the unique research interests of those scholars who are studying Indian Philosophy.



3. History of Indian Philosophy (2018) by Purushottama Bilimoria (Ed.)

Another edited volume like the above, with nearly 60 articles uncovering the diversity of the Indian philosophical landscape. This particular book does a good job at discussing the ancient traditions as well as what Indian philosophy looks like today.

Classical Yoga

1. [Yoga Sūtras of Patañjali \(2009\) by Edwin Bryant](#)

This book includes an excellent introduction to the history of the text, Sāṃkhya philosophy, and the commentarial tradition that is associated with the Yoga Sūtras.

2. [The Philosophy of Classical Yoga \(1996\) by Georg Feuerstein](#)

Georg Feuerstein is considered one of the pioneers of what we refer to as the “scholar-practitioner”. He wrote accessible overviews of many yoga topics from an informed and well-researched perspective. While some of his perspectives have been debunked by recent scholarship, his books continue to be inspiring texts for the practitioner who is seeking to go deeper into study and practice.

3. [Classical Sāṃkhya: An Interpretation of its History & Meaning \(1969\) by Gerald James Larson](#)

A more academic text than some of the others in this list, the late luminary scholar Gerald James Larson offers perhaps the best philosophical explanation of the text and the sāṃkhya philosophical system available.

4. [The Eight Limbs of Yoga: A Handbook for Living Yoga Philosophy \(2015\) by Stuart Ray Sarbacker & Kevin Kimple](#)

“Many people think yoga simply means postures and breathing. Not true. The intention of this short guide is practical and straightforward: to say what yoga really is and to apply its principles to everyday life” (from amazon description).

5. [Bhagavad Gita: Talks Between Soul and God \(2010\) by Ranchor Prime](#)

This text is recommended by an EP faculty member as an accessible introduction to the Bhagavad Gītā.

6. [The Bhagavad-Gita: Krishna's Counsel in Time of War \(1986\) trans. by Barbara Stoler Miller](#)

When it comes to the Yoga Sūtras and the Bhagavad Gītā, it is good to have a couple different translations to compare with. This translation by Barbara Stoler Miller is considered by many in the scholarly community to be one of the best translations available.

Sanskrit

1. [Yogāvatāraṇam: The Translation of Yoga \(2015\) by Zoe Slatoff](#)

This text, by a faculty member of Embodied Philosophy, was written expressly with yoga practitioners in mind. It is thus perhaps the best textbook for a yoga practitioner and teacher, as it uses references to the yoga tradition extensively, while other Sanskrit textbooks have wider Indian literary reference – not all of which will be of interest to the yoga practitioner.

2. [The Language of Yoga: Complete A-to-Y Guide to Asana Names, Sanskrit Terms, and Chants \(2020\) Nicholai Bachman](#)

Another accessible text for yoga practitioners, this book is not necessarily the book you need to fully learn Sanskrit, but it is a great glossary of terms, pose names and chants – all which are necessary to command a rudimentary but responsible knowledge of Sanskrit in your classes.

3. [The Cambridge Introduction to Sanskrit \(2017\) by A. M. Ruppel](#)

For the serious student of Sanskrit without a background in the study of classics, like ancient Greek or Latin, this is an extremely thorough and effective introduction. You can evolve in the direction of translating skills with this book alone.

4. [Complete Sanskrit \(1976\) by Michael Coulson](#)

Of all the books on this list, this is the most difficult Sanskrit text. It assumes a relative background knowledge and education in the classics, particularly in Ancient Greek and Latin, and therefore is not an easy book to pick up and run with without an experienced guide. This is therefore an “advanced” introduction, and we recommend beginning with The Cambridge Introduction or Yogāvatāraṇam if you are going to try and teach yourself Sanskrit.

Vedānta

1. Unifying Hinduism: Philosophy and Identity in Indian Intellectual History (2010) by Andrew J. Nicholson

“Drawing on the writings of philosophers from the late medieval and early modern traditions, the author shows how influential thinkers portrayed Vedānta philosophy as the ultimate unifier of diverse belief systems” (from the back cover). An excellent, well-written study.

2. The Upanishads (2007) by Eknath Easwaran

One of the most accessible introductions, Easwaran’s translation is a good place to start, but we recommend moving onto more advanced translations and commentaries when the basics have been understood.

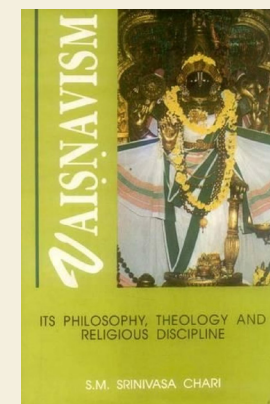
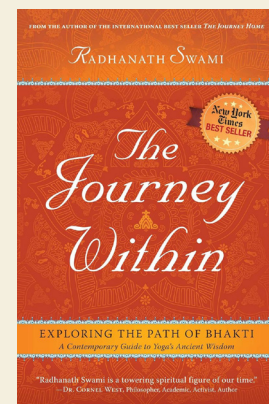
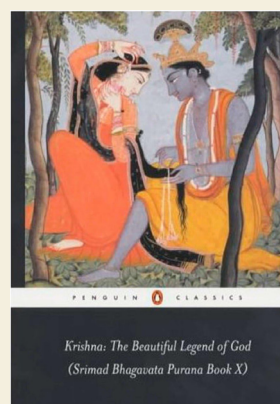
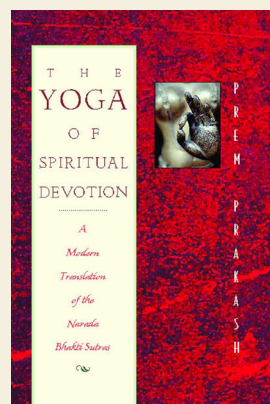
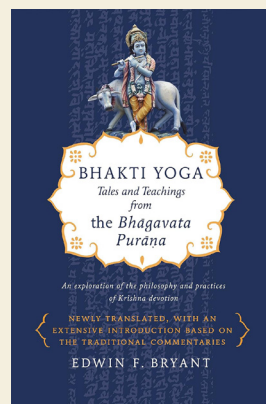
3. Upaniṣads: A New Translation (2008) by Patrick Olivelle

Patrick Olivelle is widely considered to be one of the best translators of the Upaniṣads. Amazon describes this translation as “the first major English translation of the ancient Upanisads for over half a century, Olivelle’s work incorporates the most recent historical and philological scholarship on these central scriptures of Hinduism.”

4. The Wisdom of Vedanta: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Non-Dualism (1991) by Swami Abhayananda

An easy to read introduction to the non-dualism (advaita) tradition of Vedānta. This text focuses on the theme of self-realization, by someone who purports to have tasted some of this experience himself.

Vaiṣṇava-Bhakti



1. **Bhakti Yoga: Tales and Teachings from the Bhagavata Purana (2017) by Edwin Bryant**

A companion to his translation of the Yoga Sūtras, popular yoga philosophy teacher Edwin Bryant offers a similarly accessible-yet-scholarly introduction to the philosophy and practices of a Vaiṣṇavi-Bhakti tradition.

2. **The Yoga of Spiritual Devotion: A Modern Translation of the Narada Bhakti Sutras (1998) by Prem Prakash**

An oft-neglected bhakti text (by comparison to the Bhagavad Gītā or the Bhagavata Purana), the Narada Bhakti Sutras is a beautiful and concise introduction to the path of devotion.

3. **Krishna: The Beautiful Legend of God (Śrīmad Bhāgavata Purāṇa Book X) (2016) by Edwin Bryant**

Krishna is well-known as the main character, next to Arjuna, of the Bhagavad Gita, but the stories of Krishna are wide-ranging and fundamental to understanding much devotional Bhakti from the Krishna traditions.

4. **The Journey Within: Exploring the Path of Bhakti (2016) by Radhanath Swami**

This is one of the most inspiring books written in the “spiritual quest” genre over the last 10 years. For anyone looking for a book to nourish their commitment to living a spiritual and contemplative life, this is it.

5. **Vaiṣṇavism: It's Philosophy, Theology, and Religious Discipline (1994) by S.M. Srinivasa Chari**

This is a comprehensive introduction to the historical foundation of devotional philosophy, in both theory and practice, in the Vaisnava tradition. Students will get a thorough grounding in Vaisnavism and be able to place the schools of thought that proceeded from Ramanuja in perspective.

Śaiva-Śākta Tantra

1. **The Triadic Heart of Śiva: Kaula Tantricism of Abhinavagupta in the Non-Dual Shaivism of Kashmir (1989) by Paul Muller-Ortega**

“This book explores one of the most explicit and sophisticated theoretical formulations of tantric yoga. It explains Abhinavagupta’s teaching about the nature of ultimate reality, about the methods for experiencing this ultimate reality, and about the nature of the state of realization, a condition of embodied enlightenment. The author uncovers the conceptual matrix surrounding the practices of the Kaula lineage of Kashmir Shaivism.”
(from the back cover)

2. **“Śaivism and the Tantric Traditions” (1988) by Alexis Sanderson**

This is a concise, accessible overview of the Śaiva canon and practice in the context of Tantric religion broadly, written in typically brilliant prose.

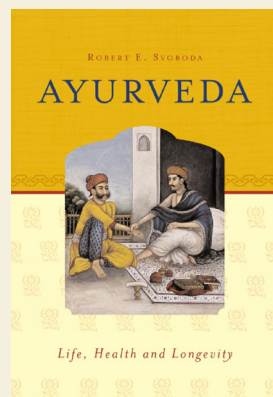
3. **The Tantric Body: The Secret Tradition of Hindu Religion (2005) by Gavin Flood**

Written with keen insight on how Śaiva (and other forms of) Tantra functions as a complete world view, linking the individual to society and the Godhead reflected in that society through its various cultural expressions.

4. **Tantra Illuminated: The Philosophy, History and Practice of a Timeless Religion (2013) by Christopher Wallis**

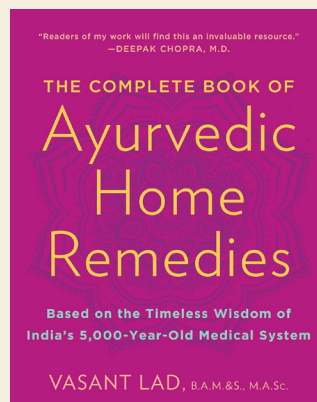
Contextualizes the canon of Śaiva Tantra with a specific focus on the non-dual Trika Kaula Śaivism of Abhinavagupta. Written with scholarly insight and a sensitivity to the interests of practitioners.

Ayurveda



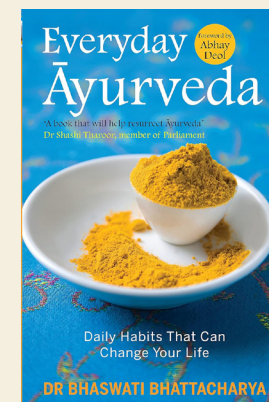
1. Ayurveda: Life, Health, and Longevity (2004) by Robert Svoboda

In this primer, Svoboda explains the history of Ayurveda, its basic principles and applications in our daily lives for expand the scope of our lives, including mental and physical health as well as longevity. Robert E. Svoboda, BAMS is a Texan who left medical school to study Ayurveda in the 1980s, and is the first American to be licensed to practice Ayurveda in India. He is author of 12+ books on Ayurveda.



2. The Complete Book of Ayurvedic Home Remedies: based on the Timeless Wisdom of India's 5,000-Year-Old Medical System (2006) By Vasant Lad

This book is full of tried-and-true remedies that have been passed down mother to child for 10,000 years. Vasant Lad, BAMS, MASc is an ayurvedic physician, founder of The Ayurvedic Institute in Albuquerque, NM, and author of many books on ayurveda, including the Textbook of Ayurveda volumes 1-3, which are used extensively by self-study students in the USA.



3. Everyday Ayurveda: Daily Habits That Can Change Your Life in a Day (2015) by Bhaswati Bhattacharya

The foundation of all ayurvedic treatments is a good daily routine, known as dinacharya. Ayurvedic texts describe routines that align the human biochemical and bioelectric systems with the physical forces in nature -- the sun, moon, gravity, and water. This bestselling book explains in simple terms the scientific basis and the practical application for lifestyle rituals still followed by Indians today.

Buddhism

1. [Buddhist Yoga: A Comprehensive Course \(1995\) by Thomas Cleary](#)

Yoga is often associated almost exclusively with Hindu religious and contemplative traditions, but the yogic phenomenon notably extended across Hindu, Buddhist and Jain traditions. This book, by a Harvard scholar, tells the story of Buddhist yoga.

2. [The Heart of Understanding: Commentaries on the Prajnaparamita Heart Sutra \(2016\) by Thich Nhat Hanh](#)

The Heart Sutra is considered one of the seminal texts of Buddhist philosophy, and Thich Nhat Hanh is one of the most accessible buddhist teachers of the contemporary age. This book will both inform and inspire.

3. [The Heart of the Buddha's Teaching: Transforming Suffering into Peace, Joy, and Liberation \(2015\) by Thich Nhat Hanh](#)

An accessible and comprehensive introduction to the teachings of the Buddha.

4. [The Golden Age of Indian Buddhist Philosophy \(2018\) by Jan Westerhoff](#)

One of the more academic texts on this list, this book will give a grounded overview of the history of Indian Buddhist philosophy by one of the most respected modern scholars of Buddhism today.

